

Complex Punctuation

Name: _____

Date: _____

Year 6 English — Grammar

ACARA v9.0: AC9E6LA09

Learning Intention

I am learning to use commas correctly for lists, to separate clauses, and in dialogue, and to explore semicolons, colons and dashes.

Success Criteria

- I can use commas to separate items in a list.
- I can use a comma to separate a dependent clause from an independent clause.
- I can use a semicolon, colon or dash correctly in a sentence.

Comma, Colon, Semicolon, Dash

Comma: separates list items or clauses. Colon: introduces a list or explanation. Semicolon: joins two related independent clauses. Dash: adds extra information.

Worked Example

We needed three things: eggs, flour and milk.
(Colon introduces the list; commas separate the items.)

Part A — Warm Up

Circle the correctly punctuated list: **I like apples pears and grapes. I like apples, pears and grapes.**

True or False: A semicolon can join two related independent clauses. _____

Name the punctuation mark that introduces a list or explanation. _____

Part B — Core Skills

Add commas to this list: *We packed a tent sleeping bags and a torch.*

Join with a semicolon: *The rain stopped. The sun came out.*

Add a comma to separate the clauses: *Although it was late we kept walking.*

Use a dash to add extra information to: *The cave was empty except for one thing.*

Punctuation Word Bank

comma • colon • semicolon • dash • independent clause • dependent clause • list • boundary punctuation

Working Space — Write 2 Sentences Using a Colon and a Semicolon

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Part C — Challenge: The Camp Report

A Year 6 student wrote in their camp report: "We needed to pack carefully: sleeping bags, torches and warm clothes. The weather was cold; we were glad we packed extra jumpers."

Q8. Identify the colon and semicolon in the report and explain what job each one is doing.

Q9. Rewrite the second sentence (with the semicolon) as two separate simple sentences instead.

Q10. Explain why the student chose a semicolon instead of just starting a new sentence with 'We were glad...'

Answer Key — Part A

A1: I like apples, pears and grapes.

A2: True — a semicolon can join two related independent clauses.

A3: A colon.

Answer Key — Part B

B1: We packed a tent, sleeping bags and a torch.

B2: The rain stopped; the sun came out.

B3: Although it was late, we kept walking.

B4: Any correctly punctuated sentence using a dash (e.g. "The cave was empty — except for one thing.") — teacher to check.

Answer Key — Part C

C8: Colon: introduces the list of items to pack. Semicolon: joins two closely related independent clauses (the weather being cold, and being glad they packed jumpers).

C9: The weather was cold. We were glad we packed extra jumpers.

C10: The semicolon shows the two ideas are closely connected (the cold weather directly explains why they were glad), creating a smoother, more connected flow than two separate short sentences would.

I Can Checklist

☐ I can punctuate a list with commas.

☐ I can use a colon and dash correctly.

☐ I can use a semicolon to join related clauses.